



Subject Topicality and Word Order Effect on Pronoun Interpretation : An experimental study of Korean



Ashley Hee-Yeon Kim

University of Delaware, Department of Linguistics and Cognitive Science

Introduction. Interpretation of the discourse relies on decoding the contextual information, especially that of pronominal elements can be ambiguous, and the factors that affect the interpretation may differ cross linguistically (Tollan & Heller, 2022).

- (1) Highly explicit form: the girl carrying books on Generative Grammar
Low explicit form: the girl
Pronominal/Reduced lexical form: she
Zero anaphor: $\emptyset$

Accessibility. There are different syntactic elements that are more accessible than others.

(2) NP accessibility hierarchy (Keenan & Comrie, 1977)

Subject > **Direct Object** > Indirect Object > Oblique Complement > Genitive > Object of Comparison

(3) Anaphora accessibility hierarchy (Ariel, 1988)

Zero anaphora > unstressed pronouns > stressed pronouns > ... > cleft-focus constructions > referential indefinite NPs

These hierarchies influence pronoun interpretation in the subsequent clause.

Selected References.

- Arnold, Jennifer E. 2010. How Speakers Refer: The Role of Accessibility. *Language and Linguistics Compass* 4(4). 187-203.
- Culicover, Peter W. 2013. The role of linear order in the computation of referential dependencies. *Lingua* 136. 125-144.
- Tollan, Rebecca and Daphna Heller. 2022. Pronoun resolution and ergativity: Effects of subjecthood and case in Niuean. *Language* 98(1). 157-183.

Topichood vs. Subjecthood. Subjects can either become a topic or not. When presented as a topic, it is a given/known information, while that of a subject is a new information.

- (4) a. Amanda invited Brittany to go on a bike ride.
b. Brittany was invited to go on a bike ride by Amanda.
She asked to bring snacks. (Adapted from Arnold 2010: (5))

Here, both Amanda, subject of (4a) and Brittany, topic of (4b) can be a referent of *she* in the following clause.

Linear order and structural parallelism. The processing of the sentence in linear order depends on specificity of the NP and how accessible the pronominal element is (Culicover, 2013).

- (5) Amanda likes Brittany. She went to the same school as her.

The pronoun *she* can be referred to Amanda, while *her* can be interpreted as Brittany, with regards to **parallelism** in (5).

Research questions.

- Does the topic/nominative case marker distinction in subject position affect pronoun interpretation?
- Does word order influence pronoun interpretation?

Forced choice task. The experiment is designed in a 2 x 2 factorial design, with variables such as case marking (nominative vs. topic) x word order (SOV vs. OSV). Subjects are marked with either the nominative or the topic marker in Korean, which enables the observation of topichood vs. subjecthood. Also, Korean is a word order scrambling language, which allows the flexible structure of OSV as well as the canonical SOV structure.

- (6) a. koyangi-ka kay-lul ccoc-hass-ta. kuliko ___ tol-ey kel-lye neme-cyess-ta.
cat-NOM dog-ACC chase-PST-DECL and ___ stone-LOC trip-CONN fall-PST-DECL
'A/The cat chased a/the dog. And it tripped on a stone.'
[SOV, Nominative]
- b. kay-lul koyangi-ka ccoc-hass-ta. kuliko ___ tol-ey kel-lye neme-cyess-ta.
dog-NOM cat-ACC chase-PST-DECL and ___ stone-LOC trip-CONN fall-PST-DECL
'A/The cat chased a/the dog. And it tripped on a stone.'
[OSV, Nominative]
- c. koyangi-nun kay-lul ccoc-hass-ta. kuliko ___ tol-ey kel-lye neme-cyess-ta.
cat-TOP dog-ACC chase-PST-DECL and ___ stone-LOC trip-CONN fall-PST-DECL
'A/The cat chased a/the dog. And it tripped on a stone.'
[SOV, Topic]
- d. kay-lul koyangi-nun ccoc-hass-ta. kuliko ___ tol-ey kel-lye neme-cyess-ta.
dog-ACC cat-TOP chase-PST-DECL and ___ stone-LOC trip-CONN fall-PST-DECL
'A/The cat chased a/the dog. And it tripped on a stone.'
[OSV, Topic]

Participants will be asked to choose whether the zero anaphora (*pro*) in the following clause will be interpreted as either koyangi (cat) or kay (dog) in a short amount of time.

Since zero anaphora are most accessible, they were implemented in the following clause to be subject to interpretation.

The word order and linear order, which interacts with pragmatic effects such as recency will test subject vs. direct object accessibility, as well as reveal the difference between topichood vs. subjecthood through a clear case marking distinction.